

Fifteen minutes to “nobody has to remember who paid”.

One workbook, four sheets. You type expenses; the workbook works out every person's fair share, every balance, and the transfers that clear them.

What you downloaded

- `Shared-Expense-Splitter.xlsx` — the workbook, delivered with a worked example (a flat share plus a trip to Lisbon) so you can see every part calculating before you type a thing.
- `Shared-Expense-Splitter-Quick-Guide.pdf` — this file.

The four sheets: **Setup** (your people) → **Expenses** (one row per expense — the only sheet you really work in) → **Who Owes What** (balances) → **Settle Up** (the payback plan).

Open it

Excel: double-click the file. If a yellow “Protected View” bar appears, click **Enable Editing** — that bar shows up for every downloaded file.

Google Sheets: see page 3 — it is a four-step import.

LibreOffice Calc / Apple Numbers: both open the file; minor visual differences are possible.

The first 15 minutes, step by step

1. **Look before you type.** Open **Who Owes What** and **Settle Up** once with the example data in place. That is what your own numbers will look like.
2. **Clear the example** (30 seconds): on **Expenses** select `B8:Q31` and press Delete. On **Setup** overwrite the names in `B21:B30`. **Never delete whole rows** — column A, the Check column R, the “Share of ...” column S and the hidden columns T:AG carry the formulas.
3. **Set up the group** on **Setup**: group name in `C15`, your currency label in `C16` (€, \$, £, or type your own — it appears in every money heading), and the split method you use most often in `C17`.
4. **Type your people** into `B21:B30` — up to 10. Set **Active?** to Yes. **Weight** (column D) is any number you agree on: room size in m², headcount, anything. **Nights / days** (column E) is how long each person was there. Both are optional — you only need them for the “Weights” and “Nights” split modes.
5. **Log the first expenses** on **Expenses**, one row each: date, what it was, who paid (dropdown), the amount as a plain number, a category, and how it splits. Leave **Split by** empty to use your default from `C17`.
6. **Read the answer.** **Who Owes What** shows what each person paid, their fair share and their balance; **Settle Up** lists the transfers that clear everything. Tick each one off in **Done?** as the money moves.

Two rules that keep the maths intact

① **Type only in white cells.** Grey cells and the hidden columns calculate themselves. ② **Insert new rows inside the table** (anywhere between rows 8 and 307), never below the red line in row 308 — then **copy the full row above onto the new row before typing** (right-click the row number ▶ Copy, then Paste on the new row): the copied row carries the calculation columns. A working row shows a number or “—” in column A; a freshly inserted row shows nothing there until you copy one in.

Five ways to split a single row.

The **Split by** dropdown works per row, so one workbook handles rent, a restaurant somebody skipped and a trip nobody joined for the same number of days.

Split by	What it does	Example from the file
Equal	Same share for everyone who is active. Type 0 in a person's column to leave them out of that one row.	Dinner at the seafood place, 142.80 — Ben has a 0, so the other four pay 35.70 each.
Weights	Splits by the Weight column on Setup. Somebody with no weight carries none of that row.	Rent 1,450.00 by rooms 18 / 16 / 14 / 12 m² → 435.00 / 386.67 / 338.33 / 290.00.
Nights	Splits by the Nights / days column on Setup.	Apartment 980.00 over 7 / 7 / 3 / 4 / 7 nights → 245.00 / 245.00 / 105.00 / 140.00 / 245.00.
Custom units	Splits by the numbers you type in that row. A blank cell counts as 0 — only the people you give a number to share the row.	Souvenir prints 63.00 with units 2 / 2 / 1 / 1 / 1 → 18.00 / 18.00 / 9.00 / 9.00 / 9.00.
Exact amounts	You type each person's exact amount. They must add up to the row's amount, otherwise the Check column says so.	Supermarket 76.40 → 24.90 / 15.00 / 15.00 / 21.50 (two personal items included).

The person columns H–Q

Blank = normal share · **0** = not part of this expense · **a number** = custom units, or the exact amount in “Exact amounts” mode.

One exception worth remembering: in **Custom units** and **Exact amounts** rows a blank cell means **0**, not “normal share”. Only the numbers you type share that row — and if you type none, the Check column says “*Custom units: nobody has units on this row*” instead of quietly splitting it.

Recording a cash payback

Ben hands Anna 50 in cash. Add a **normal expense row**:

- Paid by = **Ben**, Amount = **50**
- Split by = **Exact amounts**
- Type **50** in **Anna's** column, leave everyone else blank

The category “Payback / cash to a person” is only a label for your own filtering — the split mode does the maths.

“Show each person's share for ...”

Pick any name in cell **C4** on the Expenses sheet. Column **S** then shows that person's share of every single row — the fastest way to answer “why do I owe that much?”.

Import in four steps.

Google Sheets

1. Go to `sheets.google.com` and open a blank spreadsheet.
2. Menu **File** → **Import** → **Upload**, choose `Shared-Expense-Splitter.xlsx`.
3. Pick **“Replace spreadsheet”** and confirm.
4. Rename the file and share it with the group (top right, **Share**) — everyone can log their own expenses.

What comes across: formulas, dropdown lists, conditional colours, frozen rows and columns, tab colours and the hidden calculation columns.

What does not: the print setup (US Letter, fit-to-width). If you want to print from Google Sheets, choose “Fit to width” once in its print dialog.

The workbook was built for this trip on purpose: no macros, no Excel-only functions, no dynamic arrays, and every dropdown points at a visible cell range on the Setup sheet.

Which cells are grey (and hidden) — and why

Grey means **“this cell calculates itself — never type here”**. It is not protected, so you can always look inside; it just does not want your input.

Sheet	Calculated area	What lives there
Expenses	A · R · S, and the hidden block T:AG	Row number, the Check message, the selected person’s share, and the split engine (units per person, total units, divisor, amount).
Who Owes What	the whole sheet	Six tiles, one balance line per person, the totals row.
Settle Up	A–E, plus the hidden block J:V	The transfer list and the balances after each step. You only type in Done? and Note .
Setup	the Check column G	Warns you if two members end up with the same name.

Curious? Click the small “+” outline button above column AH — or select columns S and AH, right-click and choose “Unhide” — to watch the engine work. Nothing breaks as long as you do not type in it.

What the Check column tells you

Every logged row gets a plain-English verdict in column **R** — and the dashboard counts the rows that still need a fix:

- **OK** — complete and shared by someone.
- Who paid? · Payer is not in the member list on Setup
- Amount must be a plain number — no currency symbol, no text
- Custom units: nobody has units on this row — type a number for at least one person
- Nobody shares this row — check the person columns H–Q, and the Weight / Nights columns on Setup
- Exact amounts do not add up to the amount

What it does — and what it doesn't.

Limits, stated plainly

- Up to **10 people** and **300 expenses** per workbook.
- **One currency per workbook.** The currency label in `C16` is a text label — there is no exchange-rate conversion.
- The payback plan uses at most **9 transfers for 10 people** ($n-1$). It clears every balance to the cent; it is **not** claimed to be the mathematically smallest possible number of transfers.
- Amounts are numbers ≥ 0 . Got money back? Lower that expense's amount, or record the cash between two people as its own "Exact amounts" row.
- No macros, no add-ons, no login, no bank connection. It is a file on your computer.

FAQ

Somebody joined halfway through the trip. Put their real number of nights in column E on Setup and use the "Nights" split for the shared accommodation.

Someone left the group. Set Active? to No — past expenses keep their maths, new rows leave that person out.

The balances don't add up to 0.00. That total line is the alarm: one of your rows is shared by nobody. The Check column names the row.

I need more than 300 rows. Start a second workbook (a new month, a new trip). Rows below the red line in 308 are not counted.

Where the odd cent goes

Balances are rounded to whole cents. Before the plan is built, the leftover cent is given to whoever is owed the most, so the plan closes at exactly 0.00. One person can therefore end up a cent or two away from the balance shown above — that is the rounding, not an error.

The cell "**Left over after plan**" on Settle Up proves it: green at 0.00, red if anything is left.

Scope

For personal and household use. This is a calculation sheet, not accounting software: no VAT or tax calculation, no currency conversion, and no legal or financial advice.

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